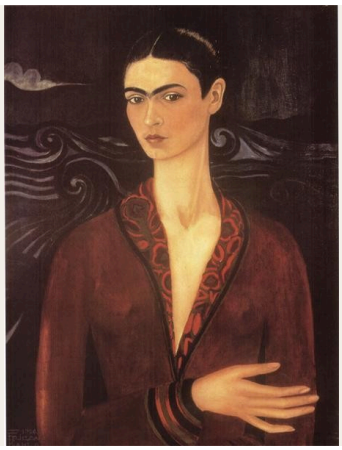
1907–1954

Frida Kahlo: what a self-portrait can contain

A face can share its picture with a family tree, a divided landscape, an animal body or a second self.



Kahlo's face is so familiar that it can draw attention away from the decisions surrounding it. The same direct look appears inside very different constructions: a formal dress, an exposed hospital bed, a border between countries, a thicket of animals and leaves. Sometimes the body doubles. Sometimes it changes species.

This guide follows those changes without treating every object as a code with one authorised solution. Paintings of relatives and other sitters help widen the account. So do words, frames and mirrors, which can belong to the work as materially as its painted surface. A self-portrait here is not simply a likeness accompanied by biography; it is a place where relationships can be arranged.

Twenty editorial choices, not a complete catalogue. The selection includes explicit images of pregnancy loss, bodily injury and blood where these are part of the artwork. Reproductions retain their recorded credits and rights labels.

Explore this selection in Artline

Open these twenty works alongside books and events from their period. The lifespan view includes Frida Kahlo, Diego Rivera, Georgia O'Keeffe, Tarsila do Amaral and Remedios Varo. These comparisons provide historical context, not claims of direct influence.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/frida-kahlo

The selection · 20

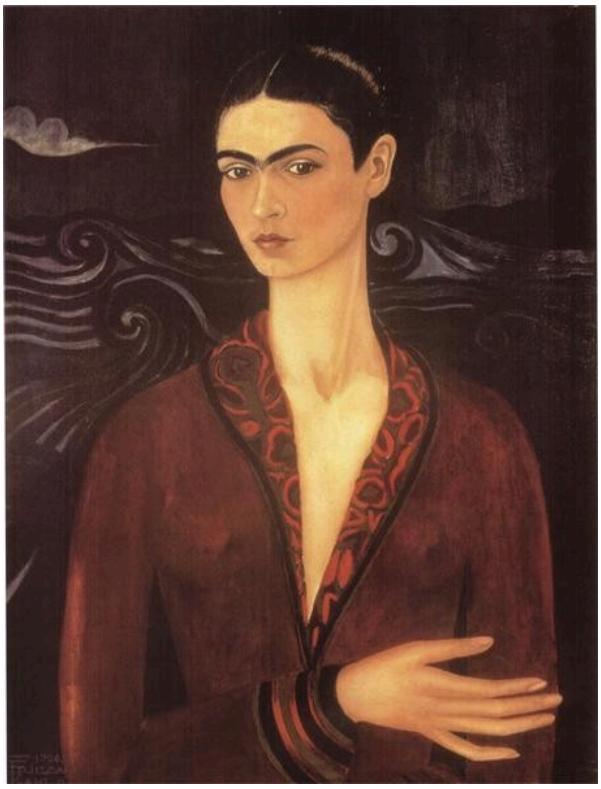
1. Self-Portrait in a Velvet Dress
   Frida Kahlo · 1926
2. The Bus
   Frida Kahlo · 1929
3. Frieda and Diego Rivera
   Frida Kahlo · 1931
4. Henry Ford Hospital (The Flying Bed)
   Frida Kahlo · 1932
5. Self-Portrait on the Border between Mexico and the United States
   Frida Kahlo · 1932
6. My Grandparents, My Parents, and I
   Frida Kahlo · 1936
7. Fulang-Chang and I
   Frida Kahlo · 1937; assembled after 1939
8. Self-Portrait Dedicated to Leon Trotsky
   Frida Kahlo · 1937
9. The Frame
   Frida Kahlo · 1938
10. The Two Fridas
    Frida Kahlo · 1939
11. Self-Portrait with Cropped Hair
    Frida Kahlo · 1940
12. Self-Portrait with Thorn Necklace and Hummingbird
    Frida Kahlo · 1940
13. Self-Portrait with Monkey and Parrot
    Frida Kahlo · 1942
14. Self-Portrait with Monkeys
    Frida Kahlo · 1943
15. Portrait of Doña Rosita Morillo
    Frida Kahlo · 1944
16. The Broken Column
    Frida Kahlo · 1944
17. The Wounded Deer
    Frida Kahlo · 1946
18. Diego and I
    Frida Kahlo · 1949
19. Portrait of My Father
    Frida Kahlo · 1951
20. Viva la Vida, Watermelons
    Frida Kahlo · 1954

01 / 20

Self-Portrait in a Velvet Dress

Frida Kahlo

1926



Frida Kahlo; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The extended neck and deep red dress create a deliberately formal self-presentation. Against it, embroidery and the restless background introduce curling movement. Kahlo's face holds a controlled position while the surrounding forms refuse to remain still. Compared with the crowded later portraits, this early painting gives proportion and fabric much of the work of defining a public appearance.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

The Bus

Frida Kahlo

1929



Frida Kahlo; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

A shared bench does not erase differences. Work clothes, a hat, a basket and a carried child distinguish passengers within the same enclosed row. The windows place them against a city without dispersing the group into it. This is a useful counterweight to the self-portraits: Kahlo also constructs pictures from the social relations among people other than herself.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Frieda and Diego Rivera

Frida Kahlo

1931 · oil , canvas · San Francisco Museum of Modern Art (SFMOMA), San Francisco, CA, US



WikiArt; Frida Kahlo · Public domain

Rivera holds the palette and brushes, but Kahlo painted the picture. That distinction complicates the difference in their apparent scale. Their joined hands connect his large dark suit to her smaller, brightly dressed figure, while a written banner makes the portrait an addressed document. The image shows a partnership whose artistic work extends beyond the tools visibly assigned to one person.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Henry Ford Hospital (The Flying Bed)

Frida Kahlo

1932



Frida Kahlo; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The hospital bed has no sheltering room. After her pregnancy loss in Detroit, Kahlo placed it before an industrial horizon and linked her body by red cords to separate anatomical and other forms. Those connections gather experiences that ordinary perspective could not contain together. The surrounding emptiness makes the patient's exposure more immediate than any attempt to decode each object separately.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Self-Portrait on the Border between Mexico and the United States

Frida Kahlo

1932 · oil , metal



WikiArt; Frida Kahlo · Public domain

Kahlo stands where the picture's two systems meet. Plants and historical forms occupy one side, factories and machinery the other; below, roots and cables provide competing networks of connection. This division is an argument about place, not a geographical survey. Her position on the pedestal lets the self-portrait hold the comparison together without making the landscapes continuous.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

My Grandparents, My Parents, and I

Frida Kahlo

1936 · Oil and tempera on zinc · Museum of Modern Art



Frida Kahlo; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The red ribbon makes kinship visible. It joins generations that cannot plausibly occupy one scene at the same scale, ending with the child in the courtyard. The parents' wedding clothes give another moment in family time a place above the house. Perspective yields to genealogy: position and connection explain the relationships more clearly than a naturalistic group portrait could.

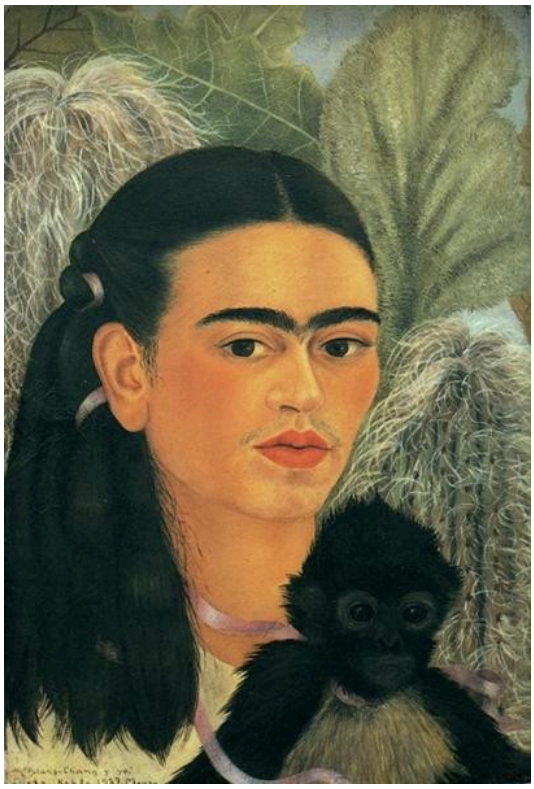
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 102.1976

07 / 20

Fulang-Chang and I

Frida Kahlo

1937; assembled after 1939 · oil , masonite · Museum of Modern Art



WikiArt; Frida Kahlo · Public domain

The painted monkey shares Kahlo's close space among leaves and ribbon. But the familiar panel reproduction is only part of the MoMA object: a separate mirror was assembled with it after the painting was made. That addition allows a viewer's reflection to stand beside the painted company. The work's physical construction changes the terms of the portrait.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

Self-Portrait Dedicated to Leon Trotsky

Frida Kahlo

1937 · oil , masonite · National Museum of Women in the Arts



Frida Kahlo; reproduction via WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Parted curtains make the standing figure appear formally presented. Flowers and an inscribed letter give her hands objects to offer, and the dedication names the portrait's recipient. Unlike the close animal portraits, this image leaves room for a public, full-length appearance. Its social purpose belongs to the composition, not merely to an anecdote added after it.

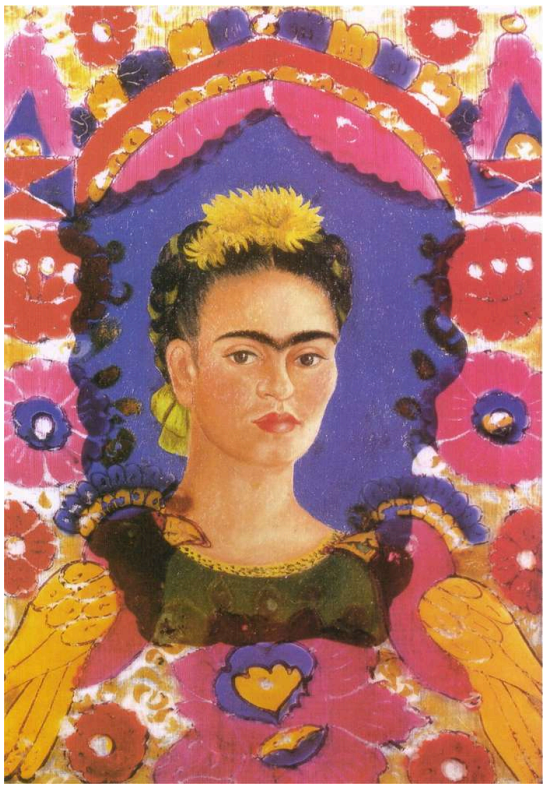
Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

The Frame

Frida Kahlo

1938 · Oil on aluminium, with painted-glass surround · Centre Pompidou



Frida Kahlo; reproduction via WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The flowers and birds belong to a painted-glass surround combined with the small metal portrait. They are not simply background scenery on the same surface. The overlap makes Kahlo's face appear through another object, bringing Mexican decorative craft into the construction of the work. Separating image from frame would remove a central part of its appearance.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: JP 929 P (1)

10 / 20

The Two Fridas

Frida Kahlo

1939 · Oil on canvas · Museo de Arte Moderno



Frida Kahlo; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Dress divides the seated figures; hands and a blood vessel connect them. Kahlo gives each a visible heart without making their expressions dramatically different. The doubled body carries distinctions the face alone does not display. Blood on the pale skirt makes one connection vulnerable, yet the clasped hands persist. Separation and attachment occupy the same composition.

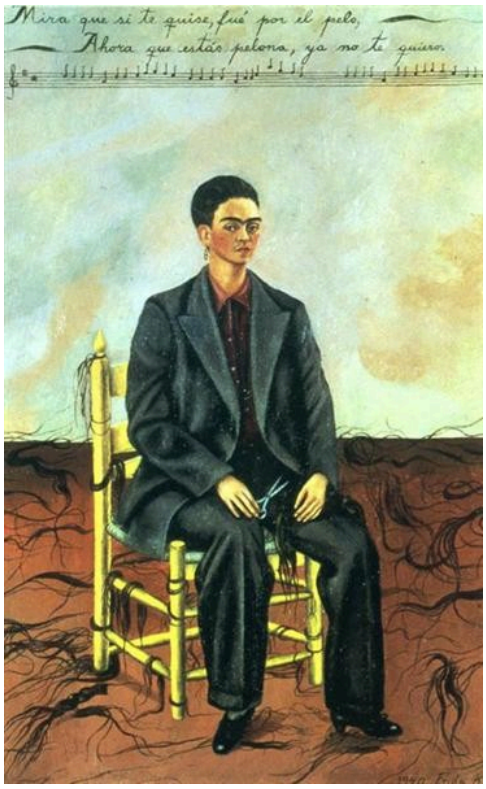
Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

Self-Portrait with Cropped Hair

Frida Kahlo

1940 · Oil on canvas · Museum of Modern Art



Frida Kahlo; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The cut hair remains on the floor as evidence of an action. Seated in a loose suit with scissors in hand, Kahlo presents both a changed appearance and what that change has removed. Lyrics at the top introduce another voice into the image. They complicate the act's relation to love and feminine presentation without settling it into one unequivocal statement.

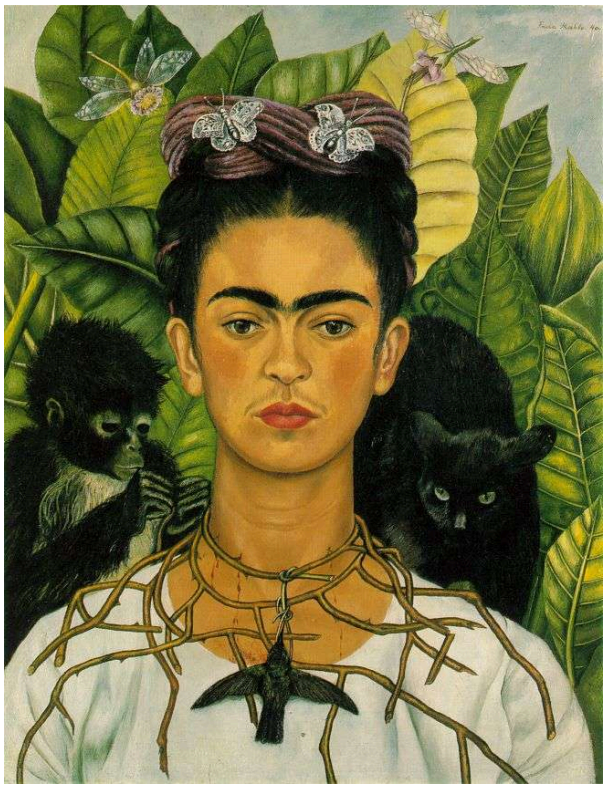
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 3.1943

12 / 20

Self-Portrait with Thorn Necklace and Hummingbird

Frida Kahlo

1940 · oil , canvas · Harry Ransom Center



Frida Kahlo; reproduction via WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The steady face is surrounded by things that touch, crowd or puncture its space. Thorns catch at the neck; animals appear beside the shoulders; leaves close the distance behind. That pressure is observable even without a fixed symbolic key for the hummingbird, monkey and cat. The portrait's restraint depends partly on how much activity the surrounding forms absorb.

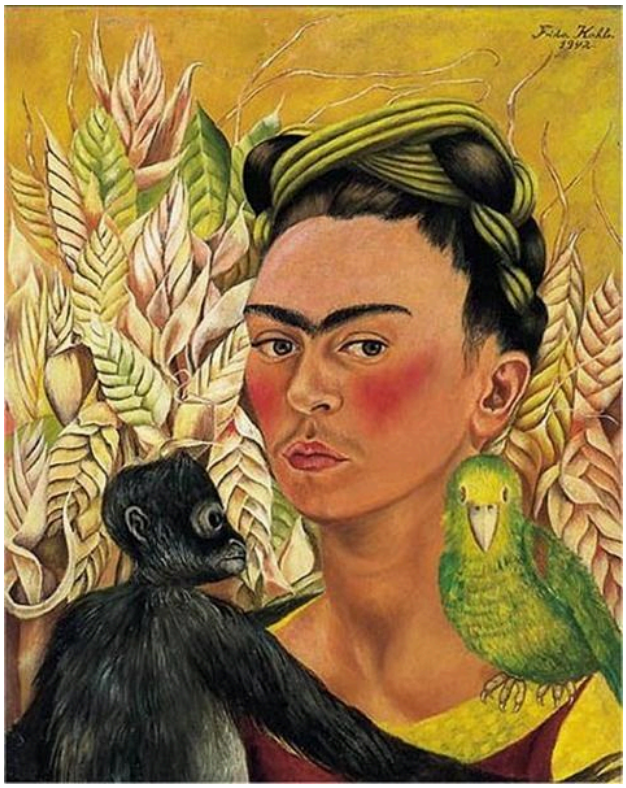
Object source · Open artwork

13 / 20

Self-Portrait with Monkey and Parrot

Frida Kahlo

1942 · Óleo sobre masonite · Museo de Arte Latinoamericano de Buenos Aires (Malba)



Frida Kahlo; Museo de Arte Latinoamericano de Buenos Aires (Malba); Colección Malba. Donación Eduardo F. Costantini, 2003; WikiArt · Public domain

The animals occupy opposite sides of the face but do not balance it identically. The monkey remains dark, while the green parrot approaches the colouring of the garment below. A slight turn of the head disrupts symmetry further. Repeated ingredients produce a different portrait because their colours and directions have been rearranged.

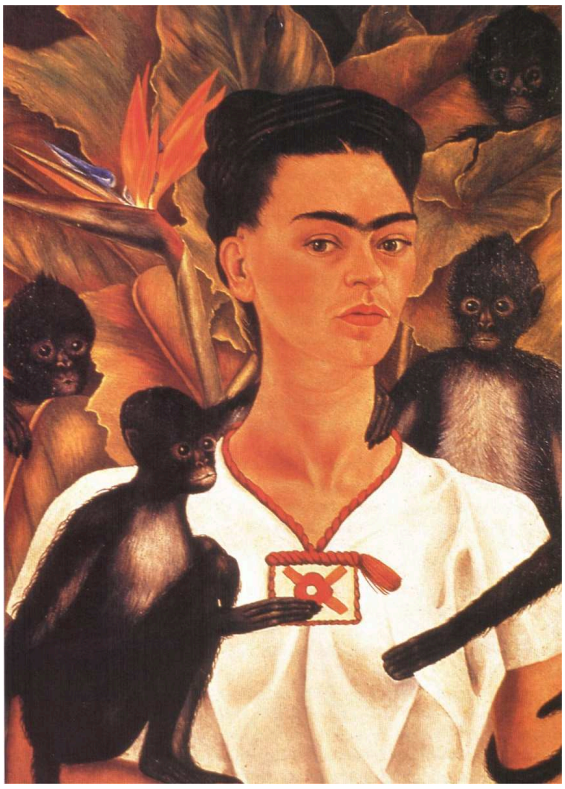
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2003.34

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Self-Portrait with Monkeys

Frida Kahlo

1943 · oil , canvas



Frida Kahlo; reproduction via WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Several animal bodies leave little unoccupied space around the white blouse. Their limbs and the surrounding leaves make the figure's clear facial outline especially important. Increasing the number of companions changes the portrait's density, not just its cast. Kahlo's stillness can hold the centre because movement and overlap have been distributed around it.

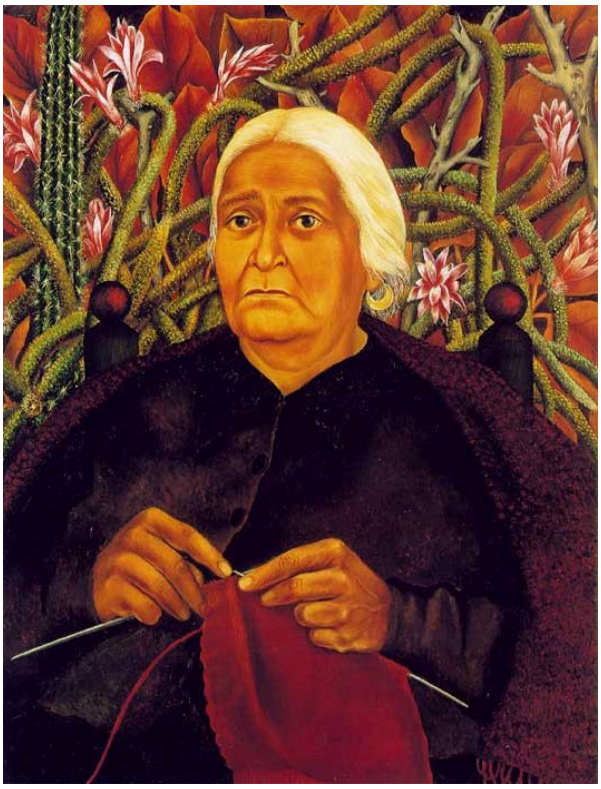
Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

Portrait of Doña Rosita Morillo

Frida Kahlo

1944 · oil , masonite



Frida Kahlo; reproduction via WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Pale yarn and knitting needles direct attention to the sitter's hands against her dark dress. Plants provide the enclosure familiar from Kahlo's self-portraits, but the older face belongs unmistakably to another person. The activity gives the hands a purpose without explaining away the sitter's expression. The repeated format leaves room for individual age and appearance.

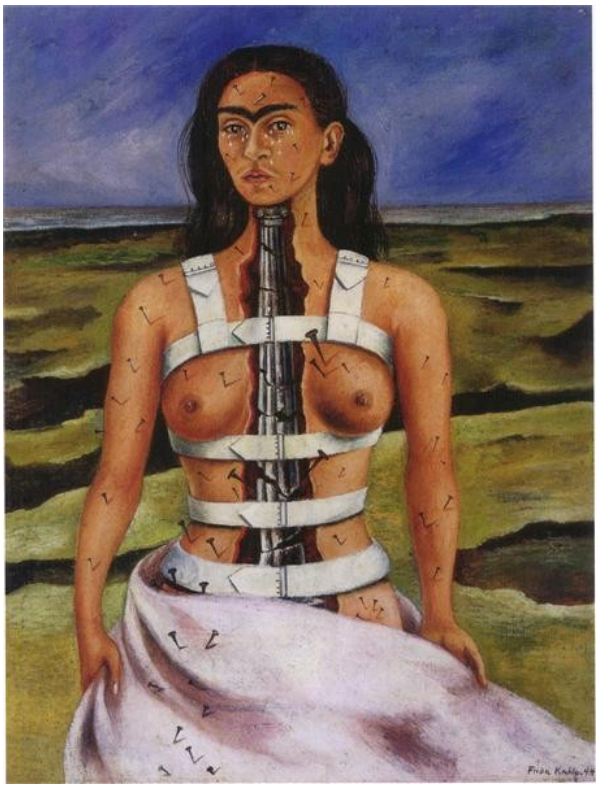
Object source · Open artwork

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The Broken Column

Frida Kahlo

1944



Frida Kahlo; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

An architectural support replaces the hidden structure inside the torso, and it is fractured. Straps hold the body while nails and tears register pain at its surface. Fissures extend into the landscape behind. The painting makes bodily damage visible through an impossible construction; it need not be mistaken for a medically exact illustration to be precise about vulnerability.

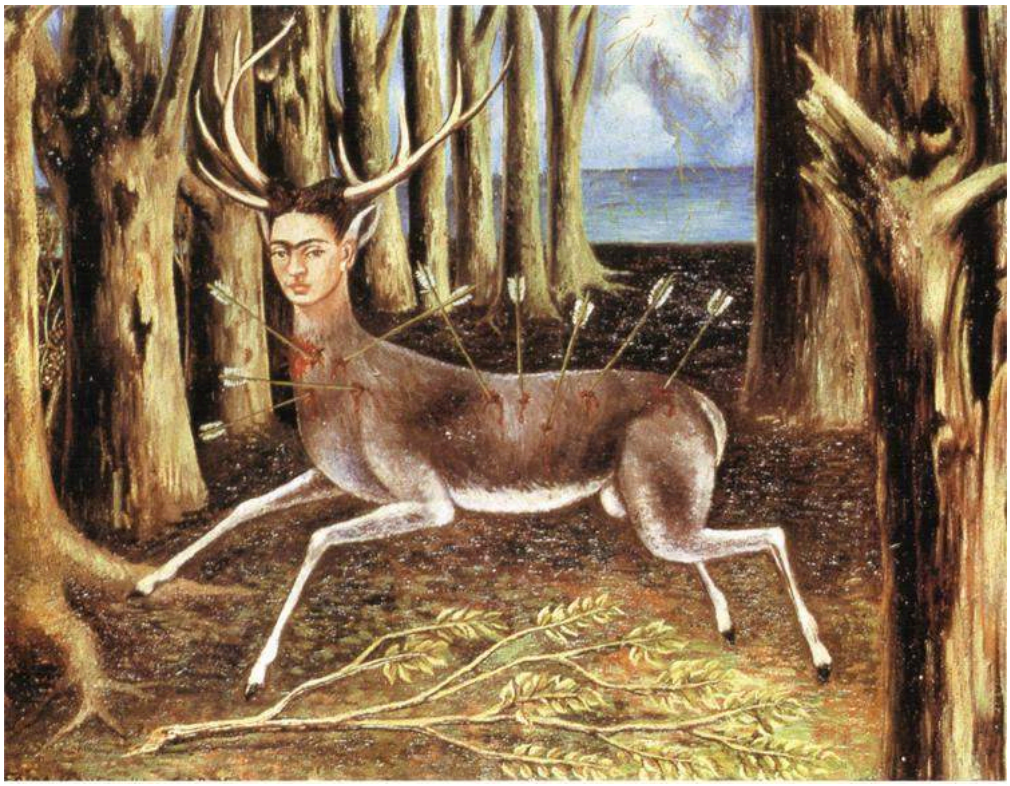
Object source · Open artwork

17 / 20

The Wounded Deer

Frida Kahlo

1946



Frida Kahlo; WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The human face preserves Kahlo's identity while the deer's body changes its capacity for movement and injury. Arrows penetrate the animal, and enclosing trunks divide the forest into narrow intervals. An opening appears beyond, but the composition supplies no clear route toward it. The hybrid figure remains caught between recognisable likeness and a body that cannot protect itself.

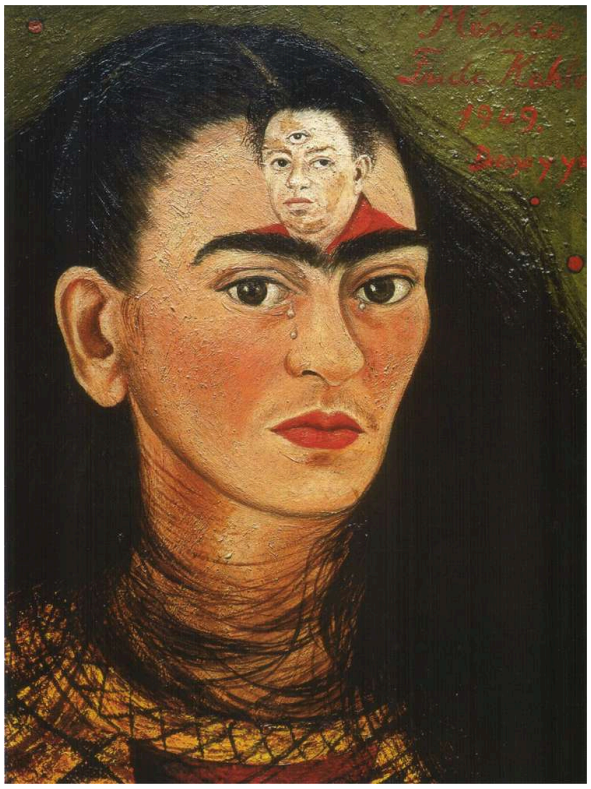
Object source · Open artwork

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Diego and I

Frida Kahlo

1949 · oil , canvas , masonite



Frida Kahlo; reproduction via WikiArt · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Rivera's small portrait occupies Kahlo's forehead, bringing a relationship inside the boundaries of the self-image. His additional eye makes the inset face altered rather than simply miniature. Around it, tears and loose hair concentrate attention on Kahlo's face and neck. The compression removes the need for a room or landscape to describe how the figures are connected.

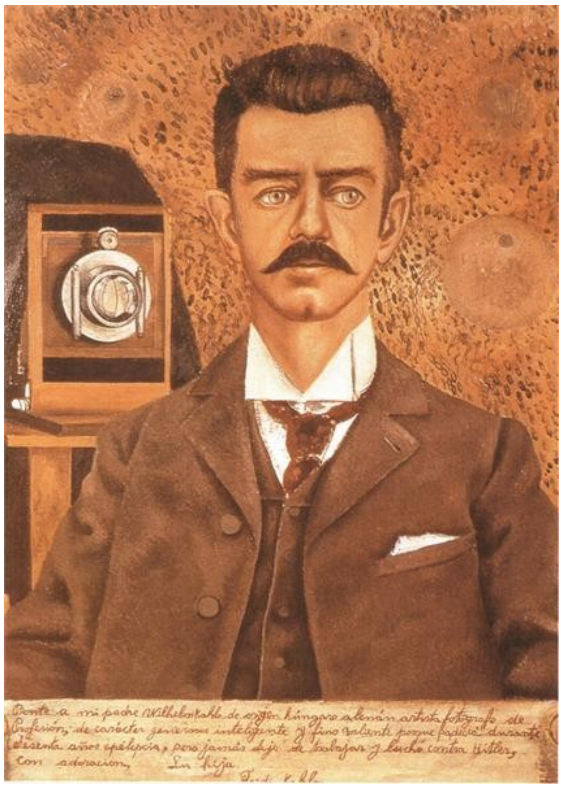
Object source · Open artwork

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Portrait of My Father

Frida Kahlo

1951 · oil , masonite



WikiArt; Frida Kahlo · Public domain

The camera identifies Guillermo Kahlo's working life, while the inscription provides an account that likeness cannot supply. Painting and writing therefore perform different kinds of remembrance. His formal clothes establish a composed appearance; the words beneath it belong to his daughter's testimony. The portrait does not ask the face alone to prove personal character.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Viva la Vida, Watermelons

Frida Kahlo

1954 · oil , masonite



WikiArt; Frida Kahlo · Public domain

The inscription, meaning “Long live life,” sits within the red flesh of a cut melon. Words remain attached to rind, seeds and uneven slices rather than floating above the still life as a slogan. With no human face in the picture, repeated colours and shapes take over the task of holding its crowded arrangement together.

Object source · Open artwork

Keep the object beside the image

Compare a self-portrait with one of the portraits of other people, then return to a work that includes writing or a separate surround. The differences become clearer when familiar biography does not do all the explaining. Consult the holding institution for current display, and check reproduction rights independently; a freely circulating image is not a licence.

Further reading

The Diary of Frida Kahlo: An Intimate Self-Portrait

Frida Kahlo; introduction by Carlos Fuentes; commentary by Sarah M. Lowe · Publisher page; purchase or library

The diary places painted and written pages together. Read it beside the inscriptions in the later works, while keeping its dates distinct from the earlier paintings in this guide.

Frida Kahlo: Self-Portrait with Cropped Hair

Jodi Roberts · The Museum of Modern Art, 2019 · Free publisher sample PDF

A close study of one painting from MoMA's One on One series. The linked file is a sample, not the complete book; it offers a starting point for looking more carefully at the suit, hair and written music.

Artist resource · Museum research

Sources checked: 2026-10-12

Artline · Frida Kahlo: what a self-portrait can contain